Singapore: A Perfect City or a Highly Controlled Society?

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Introduction: The Singapore Paradox

Have you ever landed in a completely new city and felt that you stepped into a glamorous movie set? That is the experience when visit the Lion City, Singapore. The streets here are spotless, the public transport works with perfect precision and crime is at an all time low that you can walk around alone even at midnight.

Despite its futuristic attractions like Gardens by the Bay and Marina Bay Sands, Singapore is famously known as a "fine city" with very strict laws, such as bans on chewing gum and heavy fines for littering.

This raises a big question: Is Singapore an engineering masterpiece or a heavily controlled police state? The reality is that it is both at the same time, balancing great convenience and order with strict rules.

The Case for Perfection: The Utopian Side of Singapore

For many visitors who have visited or reside in this fast paced city, Singapore is seen almost as a utopian dream. Its achievements in city planning, safety, and infrastructure are unmatched. Yet, most of its successes were deliberately engineered and we mean deliberately in both senses of the word. Let's explore the reasons behind the perfection of Singapore.

1. Master planned brilliance and long term vision

- Some parts of Singapore's current master plan were drawn in 1965, when Singapore was just obtaining its independence. Back then, the country was a British colony with vast marshlands, jungles, and a bunch of shophouses a far cry from the modern skyscrapers of today. Yet, despite the seemingly impossible task of turning a swampy mudflat into a thriving global financial hub, the planners and politicians took on the challenge. They realized early on that the only way for Singapore to survive as an independent state was to undergo rapid development to accommodate millions of residents.
- Singapore had no natural hinterland and was a small island with deep water surrounding it on all sides. It could not afford the mistakes of socialism and capitalism both of which failed economically and politically. Therefore, they embarked on a radical master planning to make the best possible use of the limited land area. Instead of developing the city in a haphazard way, the government created a comprehensive vision for the country.
- The Housing and Development Board of Singapore provided 90 percent of residents their own hommes and the government deliberatrly planned to create a harmonious mix of ethnic group by using a quota system. Everyone whether you are Malay, Chinese or Indian, buys their flat in the government subsidised housing estates.

- Such an approach allowed the government to build communities with a strong sense of belonging and attachment to the country. In terms of transport and other community facilities, there is an exceptionally high level of planning that makes getting around easy, reliable, and most importantly, punctual another source of pride for the Singapore government.

2. Living city in a garden

- Most other capital cities are concrete jungles, while Singapore is a pioneer in the concept of the Garden City, which evolved into the recent City in Nature program. Vegetation plays an essential role in the urban development strategy. It serves both an aesthetic and functional purpose, separating greenery and the built environment. This approach has seen the development of such projects as the magnificent vertical gardens in hotel lobbies and restaurants, as well as the striking Changi Airport's Jewel a retail and entertainment complex with a 40-meter waterfall at its centre. Such attractions are so integrated into the city that neither tourists nor locals would think twice about visiting them.
- Urban planners ensure that the city has sufficient greenspace, separating it into categories: 'trees', 'water', and 'recreational' areas. The whole city is a carefully laid-out mosaic with gardens, nature reserves, and parks. For example, many of the highways are canopies of trees that were strategically planted decades ago. New developments have to replace sealed surfaces with plants..

3. Multiculturalism, harmony, and safety

- With a crowd of Chinese, Malay, Indian, and Eurasian citizens, Singapore includes a spirit of harmony in all aspects of life. Such diversity is challenging to achieve in most countries, but in Singapore, it is a halmark of the city.
- Safety is also a top priority for the government, which includes strict laws and punishments for offenses and tight public transport security. Thus, the citizens and visitors feel confident in the safety of them and their belongings.

The Roots of Resilience: Why the Strict Model Was Created

To better understand how Singapore's system works, we need to go back to 1965 when it became an independent republic. From the start Singapore was a small island with a very diverse ethnic makeup while also having limited resources.

Survival was not guaranteed for the new republic as it did not possess strategic resources and had little hinterland to provide raw materials for its industries. The government realized that the traditional economic and political systems laissez-faire capitalism or socialism would fail to address the unique challenges posed by Singapore's geographic and demographic realities. To overcome this dilemma, they embarked on the most ambitious planning program one that would use the land to its maximum and make every square meter count. As a result, Singapore experienced a rapid and complete transformation of its urban landscape.

This approach was necessitated by the fact that every mistake could undermine Singapore's survival as an independent state. Unlike the larger countries, Singapore could not afford a single misstep. Ethnic tensions added more instability to the newly made republic, but the govern

ment dealt with it using strict rules and regulations.

As a result, a social contract was created between the citizens and the government. The government took on the responsibility of delivering growth and stability, which it did successfully. In exchange for ethnic harmony and stability, the government asked for the citizens' support and consent to take measures to ensure stability. In other words, the government and people of Singapore are in a constant pact of mutual give and take, and neither is willing to concede the fundamentals of their positions.

The Flip Side: The Price of Order

Yet, for all of its bright attributes and convenient public transport, Singapore is a model of intense governance and social control. Here are the main controversies and downsides of the Singaporean model.

1. Culture of regulation and strict laws

- Singapore is famously known as a 'fine city', a pun on the word fine as the government employs a wide range of rules and regulations to maintain order and punish those who abuse the city's resources or disturb its carefully planned system. For example, gum was once banned in Singapore because its use in public transport caused considerable disruption people stuck the wads on the train doors' sensors, which resulted in unwanted train stops. Additionally, offenders in Singapore are often subjected to Corrective Work Orders, which require them to work in unpleasant conditions while in high-visibility vests.
- Strict rules and punishments are also imposed for smoking in public places, jaywalking, and other minor offenses. Moreover, there are bans on bringing certain fruits on public transport, with durian being the most infamous for its unbearable odour.
- In addition, the locals here do not jaywalk, simply because they have been following these rules constantly since birth and this is the primary reason why traffic jams are not a significant problem here.

2. Surveillance, governance, and political stability

- The government exercises a high degree of oversight of infrastructure development and public safety. It has implemented a system of surveillance that monitors all public places and transportation nodes a practice that has been studied extensively by social scientists. In particular, experts have noted that across the city, there are tens of thousands of cameras that keep track of all moving objects.
- Academic studies on modern surveillance practices demonstrate that the government uses a combination of digital and physical security measures to maintain stability and prevent crime. Additionally, the system has been used to monitor the spread of disease, particularly during public health emergencies.

- Singapore is a unitary parliamentary republic with a dominant party form of government, which makes disruptive protests and unbridled public criticism of the system unlikely. Furthermore, any assembly without a permit is subject to government regulations, and mass gatherings of any kind are restricted by law. While there may be independent political parties, they receive very little support from the public, and thus, have little power.
- Similarly, ordinary citizens do not engage in overt acts of disobedience, for which they would be heavily penalized by the state.

The Everyday Experience: Inside the Blueprint

Yet, for all of the government's restrictions and interference with some of its residents' freedoms, Singapore offers unparalleled comfort and convenience to its citizens and lawful visitors. For example, most parents do not worry about their children walking to school because of the overall safety. Additionally, businesses benefit from predictable regulations, low levels of corruption, and sophisticated digital services offered by the government. The latter feature allows companies to complete routine procedures, such as registering a company, quickly and conveniently.

In fact, the government's organization of society has created a culture of competition among residents. The unofficial motto of Singapore is kiasu, roughly meaning to win or be first. The expression reflects the mentality of the nation's residents and is especially evident in the education system. Children are very competitive, and the competition begins at a young age. The country's school leaving exams at age 16 are highly competitive, and students must strive to graduate from secondary school and enter university. Many families begin to invest in tuition centres at primary school to give their children an advantage over others. Furthermore, the government's control of speech and public discussions has led to self-censorship among many citizens. Most do not criticize the government publicly due to potential repercussions. Additionally, many social movements and newspapers turn to legal channels when commenting on topical and often controversial issues. Legislation limiting Internet freedom of speech allows the government to punish any criticism with fines or even imprisonment. Yet, the restrictions do not hinder political life instead, they serve to unite residents and strengthen the government.

Finally, although the government has a firm grip on society, most residents are not unsatisfied with the situation. Ordinary citizens are free to conduct their daily lives within the framework of restrictions and regulations imposed by the state.

Striking the Balance: Security Vs Freedom

According to the residents of this city, the set of restrictions that are imposed upon them guarantee their security. The government uses strict surveillance, regulation, and punishments to ensure security, while citizens willingly accept these measures in exchange for safety, comfort, and high quality of life.

For the most part, Singapore's strict rules and punishments serve as a deterrent to potential lawbreakers. They also ensure the safety of residents by eliminating many types of crimes in Singapore, from public intoxication to vandalism.

In addition, the government's surveillance of citizens is essential if we consider that Singapore is a small state so the government cannot really afford to make mistakes thus try to prevent them in way possible.

Conclusion: A Matter of Perspective

In conclusion, Singapore is neither a perfect utopia or a strictly run police state. According to most visitors, it is an example of a perfectly functioning state that puts the needs of its citizens first. At the same time, residents are willing to sacrifice some freedoms for the sake of their security and comfort.

Those who visit the city might be surprised to find that most comforts are available to everyone. The subway is very convenient for the masses, the city feels safe and food is delicious. Still there are some downsides to this way of life, the government is constantly watching over its citizens which may make some of the masses feel uncomfortable. Additionally residents cannot express their opinions freely or protest against their government which is a bit of a concern. However, if you are done with the chaos of big cities and want to experience the calm of an organized and disciplined society, then Singapore is an ideal choice.

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